



THE BRANSON POLITICAL *REVIEW*

A NOTE FROM THE EDITOR

Hello, and welcome to the first edition of the Branson Political Review. This publication came about from an initial dream to create a forum to display the academic writing of Branson Students, foster listening across partisan lines, and encourage individuals to become more informed about the political world. However, the culmination of the efforts of incredibly talented student writers transformed this dream into a reality, and I could not be more excited for it to come to fruition.

A special thank you to Dr. Talia Di Manno for serving as our faculty advisor, assistant leader Alexander Moon for serving as co-editor, and Christopher Mao for developing the website.

Reese Furhman

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SPRING 2024 EDITION

PARTISAN INHERITANCE

By Hazel Levinson

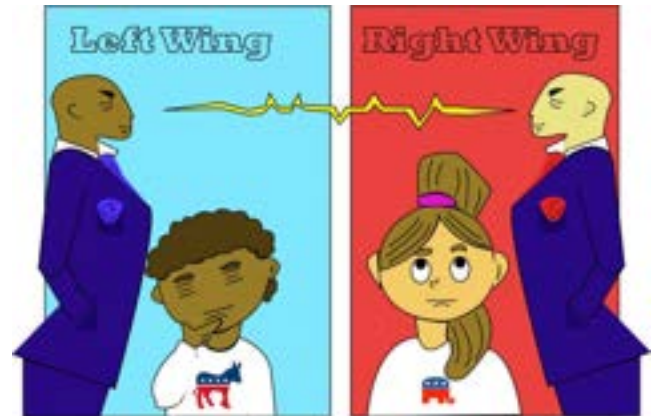
In many Democratic societies, the formation of political beliefs is influenced by a myriad of factors including family upbringing, socio-economic status, education, and media exposure. Among these, the role of the parents or influential adults in one's life is particularly significant in shaping the political attitudes.

However, whilst natural for children to be influenced by their parent's values, the direct transfer of political ideologies from one generation to the succeeding has farther reaching implications than one might assume. Implications that strike at the very core of our Democracy.

Research has reliably demonstrated children often adopt the political party that was primarily present within their childhood. This trend is evident when examining voting behavior, party identification, and ideological beliefs and tendencies. Parental political socialization shapes the attitudes and behaviors of young people. Whether through explicit or implicit discussions and actions, children are exposed to their parents' political views from an early age. Often, this occurs prior to the child having formed any opinions or beliefs independently, and can prevent them from doing so in the future. This results in children choosing the easy option, to follow their parents beliefs without question.

Social learning theory has been developed to prove that individuals pick up on the characteristics of those around them. This can be observed in speech and behavioral trends you grow to share with friends and family. While this may seem innocent, it reaches far enough to interfere with one's political orientation.

During childhood, the extent to which we are socialized by family members greatly outweighs outside factors, presenting hosts of opportunities to pick up on parents' beliefs. Secondly, psychological factors such as cognitive biases may cause children to perceive diversity in political perspectives as a direct threat on their familial and social identity, thereby reinforcing an allegiance to their parents' party.



Hazel Levinson

While it is true that future generations need to be educated about politics, an education that often occurs in one's own home, the threat is significant challenges to creative and independent political thinking later in life. This continues the polarization between political parties by creating a sense of pride belonging to a family backed party and making political orientation an inherited trait. This makes individuals less likely to seek open-minded discourse and compromises than if they were to have reached the same conclusions on their own, preventing progress and cohesion of a nation. Moreover, this transfer of policies propels existing power dynamics.

56% of the richest families in the US identify themselves with the Republican party ([Forbes](#)). In contrast, only 14% align with the Democratic party, while 30% are Independent or in agreement with both parties.

While this statistic focuses on the upper class societies of America, it is important to consider the implications of this. Often, wealthy families contribute to a politician's campaigns, and will continue to do so for generations. This reinforces the same beliefs upon the next cohorts who will ultimately be expected to support the same candidates.

Regardless of what experience prompts somebody into or out of a political party, it is crucial that future voters take time to curate their opinions, understand historical context, and challenge ideas they were raised on. This developed political socialization can be achieved through academic focuses on politics, easy to access well-rounded news outlets designed for students, as well as opportunities for open dialogue and discussions around stigmatized political issues.

Through the promotion of cross-party collaboration and inclusion, societies can take the first step towards mitigation of the effects of partisan inheritance and cultivate a more vibrant, pluralistic society. *β*

THE HISTORY OF ABORTION LAWS: HOW ONE DECISION MOVED US TWO CENTURIES BACK

By Ashley Wang

In recent years, abortion has become one of the country's most polarizing issues. In fact in 2024, one in eight voters determined abortion as their number one voting issue, with Democrats saying that they favor President Biden's reelection solely on the abortion level. Although legal abortion is consistently deemed as an "extreme liberal position" in present-day society, it is evident that throughout American history, abortion is an issue entrenched in the cultural fluctuations of the United States.



America Magazine

Starting in America's founding, abortion was a stigma-free and widespread practice among women. Americans had adopted the "quickening doctrine" from British common law. This deemed abortion completely legal before "quickening", the point at which a woman can feel the movements of the fetus—approximately four to six months into the pregnancy. Medical literature and newspapers of the time encouraged herbal concoctions as abortion-inducing methods. In fact, even post-quickening abortion was only considered a minor misdemeanor. Historians believed that these laws were put in place to protect pregnant women rather than fetal life.

However, around 1840, the first "right-to-life" movement emerged in America. Instead of conservatives, this movement was spearheaded by physicians whose leading concern was their professional status. During this time period, many other groups of miscellaneous healers had started to compete with physicians specifically in the reproductive field. Without any medical backing, physicians started to push anti-abortion laws to increase their own stature and undermine their opponents. This movement became a coverup for a larger cultural shift toward women's rights. Physicians argued that bodies could speak but they needed doctors to translate. This movement ended up being a major success, and by 1900 every single state had outlawed abortion at any stage with any method, with the only exception being protection against maternal mortality.

This change made doctors the ultimate deciders of legality and morality. As a result, little changed from 1900-1960, and police became largely involved in the process, prosecuting abortionists and harassing women who did get the procedure through the loophole.

However, a large societal shift in the 1960s aligned with the youth counterculture movement had many Americans demanding change. In 1959, the American Law Institute—a group of professionals that promoted the clarification and simplification of American law to align with social change—advocated for the liberalization of abortion law. They argued that the exceptions should be expanded to include victims of rape, fetuses that were deformed, and women whose medical health was at stake. During this period many minds similarly started to shift due to the increase in infant death and fetal deformity. At this time, American society was plagued with German measles and overuse of Thalidomide, a sleeping pill, both of which caused stillbirths and birth defects. This caused many fears amongst young couples and launched a new feminist movement which argued that women could not be full citizens without the right to their own bodies. This successfully led to several state legislature changes, starting with Colorado in 1967.



NBC

In response, the '60s also birthed the modern anti-abortion movement. Abortion became highly politicized as the movement was started by Catholic doctors, lawyers, and housewives to oppose liberalization. This caused the formation of the National Right to Life Committee and funding for the movement from the National Council of Catholic Bishops. However many pro-choice activists argued that the right-to-life movement was too religious, pushing Catholicism into a diverse American society.

Despite the church's push against abortion legalization, pro-choice advocates ultimately prevailed in 1973 with the United States Supreme Court's 7-2 decision in the *Roe v. Wade* case. The court made it abundantly clear in the majority's opinion that the United States must uphold the "fundamental right of single women and married persons to choose whether to have children [as] protected by the Ninth Amendment, through the Fourteenth Amendment." Backlash to the decision started almost overnight with Americans worried about this "one-size-fits-all" law. As a result, this landmark court case effectively made the anti-abortion movement a national one. One of the successes of the pro-life movement was the Hyde Amendment which prohibited federal coverage of abortions through Medicaid. Additionally, they used graphic images of aborted fetuses to convey the horror of an abortion. Most shockingly, abortion was linked to civil rights and human rights movements with groups arguing that the *Roe v. Wade* decision was equivalent to the *Dred Scott* decision as they both deemed groups of people "less than human".

As the pro-life movement progressed into the age of conservatism in the 1980s, activists made abortion central to social conservatism and the Republican Party. They taught children that they were survivors of the "Abortion Holocaust" and told women that they were "denying the fundamental truth of fetal life."

The pro-life movement saw its greatest success in the *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health* decision which overturned the previous *Roe v. Wade* decision. Justice Samuel Alito and the majority declared: "The Constitution makes no reference to abortion, and no such right is implicitly protected by any constitutional provision, including the one on which the defenders of *Roe* and *Casey* now chiefly rely—the Due Process Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment." In 2024, two years after the *Dobbs* decision, twenty-one states have banned abortion or set a time restraint at six weeks, more than four months earlier than the original law stated nearly two centuries ago. *B*

TIK TOK - A NATIONAL SECURITY THREAT

By Grant Kruttschnitt

Many feel that the recent law requiring TikTok to be sold within nine months or be banned came out of nowhere. However, there are many justified reasons for it that are often overlooked, especially since a majority of Gen Z are against the ban. China's influence on the company has concerning risks due to China being an adversary.



Creative Bloq

But what is the role of the Chinese Government in TikTok's parent company? There are often arguments that ByteDance is just a Chinese company, not related to the Chinese Communist Party, in the same way that most American companies are not controlled by the American government. However, this couldn't be further from the truth. The Chinese Communist Party, and ByteDance are vastly interconnected. Just like most Chinese companies, ByteDance has an oversight board composed of CCP members ([CNN](#)). They have meetings, including one where the TikTok CEO himself showed up. In addition, nearly 300 ByteDance employees used to work for Chinese State Media ([Forbes](#)). China also has a 'golden share' in ByteDance, which means they hold a controlling share in one of ByteDance's subsidiaries ([CNN](#)). This shared ownership can be, and often is exploited by the CCP to exert more control and power within the company. In addition, China has a law that requires any organization or citizen to support, assist and cooperate with national intelligence work ([CNN](#)). This means that the Chinese Government could force ByteDance to disclose intelligence information - including personal data collected by Tik Tok - at any time.

It is also important to discuss the adversarial role of China in United States foreign policy. China can be considered America's biggest rival. Not just economically, where they hold the second largest GDP, or militarily, where they have invested heavily in recent years, but also ideologically. China is an illiberal authoritarian state that suppresses rights and cracks down on freedom. They silence dissenters, either by exiling or jailing them.

This isn't a one time occurrence, but a pervasive pattern. From Tiananmen Square decades ago, where thousands of protestors were killed with tanks, to the crackdown on the Hong Kong protests last year, China is a country where citizens have very little freedom.

The government also initiates large amounts of media censorship. People are not allowed to view things past China's "Great Firewall", and almost all Western apps are banned in China ([Politico](#)). The government makes a conscious effort to shut down negative discussion and political dissent, and seeks to erase many past wrongs from their history. So much so that in China's universities, out of a survey of 100 students, only 15 of them realized what this famous Tank Man photo was, which was at the Tiananmen Square massacre ([VOX](#)). It was an event that killed thousands of people, and had worldwide impacts, yet it was virtually unknown to these students, due to China's erasing of the past. China's censorship is less severe than North Korea's information-limiting, but it still has the same concepts. In addition, the government has been condemned by the international community for their persecution of Uyghur Muslims.



CNN

As of now, more than a million are currently detained ([NYT](#)) and are often subjected to forced labor and sterilization. Anything can make them be sent to the camps, including just installing messaging apps with encryption, or violating China's limiting birth rules ([NYT](#)). They are the only real other superpower, and it is frightening to imagine what will happen as they continue to develop economically. Will their brand of authoritarianism and censorship spread throughout the world or will they slowly become more liberal as they expand?

With this in mind, it is important to address how harmful a foreign adversary controlling a main news source can be. According to Axios's survey on it, as many as 1 in 3 adults under 30 get their news from TikTok ([AXIOS](#)). China could use Bytedance's algorithms to suppress any anti-China content and promote any that is Pro-China/Anti-American. In fact, they have likely already started doing this, as shown by the Washington Post in their analysis of content about the Hong Kong protests between TikTok and various other social media platforms. There were many fewer videos on TikTok about the Hong Kong protests than videos about other protests. The difference between the videos shown on TikTok and the amount that is to be expected is incredibly dangerous, as people don't even realize what they are missing out on. It's not the propaganda of a singular force choosing what to write about, but a new and more dangerous kind of subtle interference, hidden within the algorithm. There was another study supporting this by showing that anti-China topics had much less popularity on TikTok compared to other social media platforms, such as Tiananmen Square ([A Tik-toking Timebomb](#)).

In conclusion, the threat that China's influence in Tiktok poses is very real. Therefore recent legislation requiring them to divest or be banned justified and necessary. A Tiktok ban definitely won't be the end of foreign propaganda seeping into our news sources, but it will shut down a major avenue of it. *B*

THE ELECTORAL COLLEGE: SHOULD IT STAY OR CHANGE?

By Ryka Kashi

The electoral college, a system we've maintained since its creation in 1787 during the Constitutional Convention. However is it still applicable in today's time? After all, can a system over 200 years old still be effective in a society exponentially more advanced than America in 1787? Or does this system need to be changed?



Graphic by Sam Lehman

The Electoral College system was a compromise created by the framers of the Constitution during the 1787 Constitutional Convention as a method to solve the body's disagreement in regards to how the country should elect its president. According to the Alabama Secretary of State resource page, one of the main reasons for the system's creation was to balance the power and control between small and larger states. With a population-based vote, smaller states, typically northern states at the time, would often be overpowered and overshadowed by southern states. In addition, the large southern states had the aid of the $\frac{3}{5}$ Clause allowing them to have better representation and to control the population vote far more easily.

By giving each state a certain number of votes based solely on the state's population calculated by the Census, the total number of a state's senators and representatives will determine the number of votes for the state. But if this is the case, what is the purpose of the popular vote if Americans aren't voting for their president? In actuality, the popular vote tells the state which candidate you want it to vote for. As a result, states use the popular vote results to appoint electors that will align with the general perspective of the state. In the end, the party of the winning candidate in each state selects the electors ("Distribution of Electoral Votes" 2023). In other words, the popular vote has a sway over the electoral vote so it can accurately reflect the views of the citizens of a state. But, is this always the case?

We've had five elections so far that demonstrated popular vote results that didn't correlate with those of the electoral vote. In the 1824 election, Andrew Jackson won the popular vote but John Quincy Adams won the electoral vote.

In the 1876 election, between Rutherford B. Hayes and Samuel Tilden, Tilden won the popular vote yet Hayes won the electoral vote. In another instance, the election of 1888 between Grover Cleveland and Benjamin Harrison followed this trend as Cleveland won the popular vote, but Harrison won the electoral vote and thus the presidency ("Election Listing | the American Presidency Project," n.d.). In more recent years the 2000 election between Albert Gore and George W. Bush held a lot of controversy over this same issue. According to statistics by UC Santa Barbara, Gore won the popular vote by more than half a million votes. However, Bush won the electoral vote by 5 votes, making Bush the president (UC Santa Barbara 2000). The 2016 election revealed a similar scenario where candidate Hillary Clinton won the popular vote by roughly 3 million votes. Clinton had a greater margin of victory compared to Gore's win over Bush. Yet the electoral vote demonstrated a drastic difference as Trump won by 74 electoral votes, and thus won the presidency.

These are indications of a growing unfavorable trend in our country's election practices and systems which have been becoming more frequent in most recent years. Overall, causing many to become distasteful towards the electoral system. So does the system need to change?



Smithsonian

Despite the initial purpose of the electoral system to balance power between small and large states, the founding fathers also harbored another belief that led to the system's creation. At the time, the founding fathers believed that the general public was too uneducated to make a proper decision and their opinions could be easily swayed when voting for the leader of their country. In other words, the fathers opposed direct democracy. While this might have been the case 200 years ago, is it still applicable in today's American society?

According to the National Center for Education Statistics, the percentage of illiterate adults 14 years and older began as 20% of the total American population in 1870 and has decreased to 0.6% in 1979 (National Center for Education Statistics n.d.). Comparing these statistics from the 19th centuries to the late 20th and current 21st centuries, it's clear that the general American public is currently far more literate and therefore educated than the Americans alive during the time of the electoral college's creation. If one of the main reasons for the electoral system's creation was to make sure educated officials would vote for president, then wouldn't this system be far more obsolete in today's time where a vast majority of the population is more literate, educated and knowledgeable now? Furthermore, does keeping this system display our government's lack of trust towards general Americans and their ability to vote and make educated decisions?

To get an external opinion about the Electoral College system, I talked with another student from Branson. I interviewed an anonymous Branson student regarding their opinions and views towards the electoral college.

“What are your general thoughts in regards to the Electoral College and its effectiveness?”

I believe that the system is somewhat obsolete and it doesn't do a sufficient job of representing the Democratic values that the country is supposed to maintain, as it doesn't properly represent what the people want. Furthermore, why even have the popular vote when it can get overridden by the Electoral College?

“How do you think the Electoral College affects young Americans and youth like us?”

I believe that oftentimes it can make us youth feel that our votes might not matter, particularly in a state like California. Especially since the Electoral College was designed to make sure big states like us do not have too much power or have too much of a say. But for young people like us growing up in this current time, we're all worried about the many existential crises, especially climate change. And we want to vote for a leader that reflects our concerns, but if we cannot do that, then what's the point? It begins to feel a bit hopeless.

“What do you believe are some solutions we can implement to change the Electoral College system?”

I feel that having people be able to express their opinions and their opposition towards the system is highly instrumental to enacting change. I know that it's an opinion that's definitely out there and I'm sure many politicians are aware of that, but if we took more action to let them know, especially us youth who are the future of the country, it could lead to enacting more change. If we let them know, and even if we get involved more to represent our beliefs and views, we could really make a difference.

Overall, I agree with this student, not only regarding the issues that the Electoral system imposes, but also in terms of how we can fix the system. If we as a society, especially youth, discussed more openly about the Electoral College and its effects on our country, we can spread greater awareness about the issue. This would allow a greater opportunity for the youth and general Americans to express their opinions on the system, and maybe to their representatives. If we as a society come together to express our views, then we can invoke the change we want to see in our governing body. After all, shouldn't the government serve the people it leads? *B*

SELF-EXPRESSION VS EXTREMISM: THE ORIGINS OF ANTI- LGBTQ POLICY IN RUSSIA

By Rebecca Rudy



CNN

A few weeks ago, on November 30, Russia's Supreme Court officially banned the "international LGBT social movement" from the country, designating gay rights activists and organizations as extremists. The new legislation is part of a series of recent homophobic policies enacted by the Russian government, including the expansion in 2022 of an existing anti-propaganda law targeting LGBTQ people and the introduction in July 2023 of legislation banning gender changes.

Many fear the ruling will lead not only to more arrests of LGBTQ activists, but also an increase in hate crimes and violence against the community as a whole. Since the formation of the Soviet Union, homophobia has underscored many political policies and social movements, both for and against gay rights. However, Putin's specific focus on gender and sexuality amidst his costly war with Ukraine reveals a hidden motive for the legislation; while modern Russian anti-LGBTQ laws could be seen as an extension of historical precedent, their present implementation serves Putin's agenda of strengthening the position of the Russian church and reconsolidating his hold on power.

Russia's modern anti-LGBTQ laws find some grounding in general historical homophobia and Stalin's regime, which Putin often strives to emulate. After the Russian Revolution in 1917, homosexuality was quietly decriminalized, but nothing was done to curb already existing homophobia within the Russian population. Even during this period of relative tolerance, gay men especially were still persecuted, blackmailed, or fired from their jobs as a result of their sexuality. Conditions only worsened when Stalin came to power and began to undo the work of the Bolsheviks; in the late 1920's, homosexuality was labeled a mental disorder. In 1933, whispers began to spread of the "Case of the Leningrad Homosexuals," in which almost 200 gay men were arrested for "counter-revolutionism" and "moral corruption of the Red Army." ^{CNN}

Not much about the outcome is public knowledge, as the full details are still classified today, but the case foreshadowed Stalin's complete ban of homosexuality during a series of "pro-family policies" enacted in 1934. Under Stalin, the LGBT community faced increased persecution and censorship as well as harsher policies and punishments for people, particularly men, who publicly identified as gay.

Despite underlying and explicit homophobia in the Soviet Union's past, there have also been periods of tolerance. Aside from the legalization of homosexuality under the Bolsheviks, which allowed for a brief period of freedom and self expression, there was a movement towards liberalizing LGBT policy after the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991. A spate of new laws came in the years following: homosexual relationships were decriminalized in 1993, changing of one's gender on legal documents became legal, albeit difficult, in 1997, and homosexuality was no longer considered a mental disorder in 1999. Though the authorities and much of the population still supported anti-LGBT sentiment, a budding liberalization movement was underway as protestors and activists continued to fight for expanded rights. Although there is historical precedent for current anti-LGBT policies, the movement against homophobia and towards updated policy in the post-Soviet period prevents today's extreme legislation to simply be a continuation or escalation of existing laws – a sudden change of ideology at the state level was required in order to change this trend of liberalization to one of extreme conservatism and censorship.

This shift in ideals came with the election of Vladimir Putin in 2000, whose anti-LGBTQ legislation outwardly stems from his religious background and desire to uphold Russia's "traditional values" in the face of Western influence. His first major policy in the campaign against LGBTQ individuals came in 2013, with a law banning the "propaganda of non-traditional sexual relationships to minors," making it illegal to spread the "distorted view that society places an equal value on traditional and non-traditional sexual relations." ([Russian Federation Council](#))



Wikipedia

Expanded in 2022 to include adults, this policy allowed the Russian state to greatly increase censorship and limit access to information, banning children from accessing resources about LGBTQ people and preventing the expression or normalization of non-heterosexual relationships throughout the country.

Part of this homophobic rhetoric comes from Putin's own religious background as an Orthodox Catholic and his desire to reintegrate the power of the Russian church with the power of the state, whose close relationship collapsed under the Bolshevik's anti-religion governance. On September 30, 2022, in an address on the Ukraine War, he described LGBT education in schools as "the overthrow of faith and traditional values, and the suppression of freedom [which are] coming to resemble a 'religion in reverse' – pure Satanism." By using religious language to demonize the LGBT community, Putin creates a narrative in which it is impossible for religious or traditional Russian citizens to exist as or with queer people. Later, in a Presidential Address to the Federal Assembly this February, he described Western "information attacks" on Russia, which he claims will lead to "the destruction of the family, of cultural and national identity, perversion and abuse of children...forcing priests to bless same-sex marriages."

Through linking the West with the gay community, and claiming the latter is a result of malicious Western influence that aims for the destruction of Russian values, Putin attempts to create paranoia surrounding LGBTQ people in Russia, weaponizing homophobia to further secure his own power. Through the implementation of these church-supported policies, Putin is trying to reshape Russian society around conservative values, strengthening his power by forming a stronger cultural connection between religion and government.



International Feminist Journal of Politics

Despite Putin's claim of upholding these traditional family values, today's policies in Russia have been strategically used by Putin to justify the Ukraine War and consolidate his hold on power. In several of his speeches addressing the situation in Ukraine, Putin has brought up the topic of gay people and how they act as a signal of Western moral decay, such as in the aforementioned September 30 address on the war, as well as in a speech on February 24, 2022, on the day of Russia's invasion. In this speech, he states that "[the West] sought to destroy our traditional values and force on us their false values that would erode us." Again, Putin invokes the vague motif of "traditional values" as opposed to an amorphous "West" and their relative support of queer people, pitting Russians against the West as a concept and therefore encouraging nationalism. By using this nationalism, Putin justifies the Ukraine War and maintains public support, despite the toll it has taken on the Russian people.

Putin also attempts to scapegoat the LGBTQ community through policy, framing them as agents of Western nations, and therefore as enemies of the Russian people. When the government enacted and then expanded its LGBTQ propaganda law, new legislation concerning foreign influence had also been passed. In 2012, one year before the 2013 propaganda law, a “foreign agents” policy came into effect.

Under this policy, organizations that engaged in politics and received funding from abroad would be designated “foreign agents,” or, essentially, spies. These organizations would face heavy additional rules, regulations, and censorship from the government. Additionally, in 2022 – the same year of the expansion of the propaganda policy – the foreign agents law was also expanded to include organizations that “received support or [are] under foreign influence.” The extremely vague wording of this law is purposeful; the policy can be selectively applied by the government, and the uncertainty of what one will be arrested for creates a constant state of fear and impossibility of finding a sure loophole. The policy can and has been used to limit the actions of LGBTQ rights organizations, such as by designating them “foreign agents” and therefore declaring them spies used by the West to undermine the social order. By limiting the ability of LGBTQ groups and people to self-advocate and labeling them as enemies of the state, Putin is again attempting to unite the rest of the Russian people, and possibly other homophobic nations in Eurasia, against a common enemy: the queer community, which he portrays as a tangible representation of the West.

There is not one, or possibly any, clear way to eliminate homophobia in Russia. It sits deep-rooted in policy and public opinion, exacerbated by political propaganda and misinformation.

Igor Iasine, a queer man and activist living in Moscow, said in 2014: “do not assume that human rights solutions offer a framework that all people will recognize as inherently good.” (QED) He suggested that, because the ideas of sexuality, morals, and Russia’s future are all viewed as connected, in order to make progress, the moral nature of LGBTQ and human rights need to be made explicit in mainstream media. However, since his interview, this issue has only become more complicated and difficult to address as the current administration continues to pass anti-gay legislation that limits the ability of rights groups and individuals, as well as reinforce public opinions and prejudice.

Iasine claims that previous attempts by the rest of the world to help, such as the boycott of Russia during the Sochi Olympics after the passage of the anti-propaganda law, are not extremely effective – isolation of Russia through a boycott is also isolation of the LGBT people that live there, which often will lead only to further repressive practices. He claims that participation, and working together against homophobia through social organizations and unions might be more effective. While providing support to activist groups within Russia will help LGBTQ people, after the expansion of foreign agent laws and the outbreak of the conflict in Ukraine, supporting these groups from abroad might prove difficult, if not impossible; priorities of Western nations are focused elsewhere, and Putin’s reliance on these policies to maintain power and fear will prevent him from revoking them.

Despite the perceived impossibility of reform today, in a theoretical future Russia with a stable government, economy, and society, a shift towards tolerance might become possible. In the same way Putin pulls on “tradition,” connecting anti-gay legislation to Russia’s history, activists can connect moments of tolerance in Soviet history to the present, reversing the current rhetoric.



Human Rights Watch

If Russia's leaders no longer feel they need to use fear to control their citizens, then anti-queer propaganda and policy may be allowed to dissipate. If Russian citizens no longer feel that homophobia is an integral part of their history, their attitudes may have a chance of slowly moving away from extreme conservatism.

Homophobia has been present for much of Russia's history. However, today's existing anti-LGBT policies have nearly all been shaped or used by Putin to further his own authority by strengthening the Russian church and uniting Russians against a common enemy. Despite a promising period of liberalization before Putin came to power, Russia today is becoming increasingly homophobic and intolerant, evidenced by the continued passage of extremist laws like the one passed just this November. Since their first anti-propaganda law was passed, the rate of hate crimes and violence against queer people in Russia has more than doubled, and it is clear that something must be done to curb this homophobic movement. It is difficult to pinpoint exactly what actions the global community could take that would be effective to fight Putin's rhetoric, but somehow, a message must be sent to Russia that continued expansion of their homophobic legislation will not be tolerated, and the current trend of rising censorship and violence against LGBTQ people cannot continue. Measures must be taken to support and protect queer people both within and outside of Russia, ensuring that they, along with every other marginalized community, are guaranteed fundamental human rights and liberties. *B*

BEHIND THE HEADLINES : OPPENHEIMER IN JAPAN

By Toby Walsh

In early March 2024, Christopher Nolan's film *Oppenheimer* won the Academy Award for Best Picture, and later that same month, the film was released in Japan. In the film, actor Cillian Murphy portrays J. Robert Oppenheimer, a preeminent theoretical physicist who led the Manhattan Project, an American military program that developed the atomic bomb during World War 2.



IMDB

The controversial movie was based on the biography *American Prometheus: The Triumph and Tragedy of J. Robert Oppenheimer* by Kai Bird and Martin J. Sherwin. Unlike the book, which covers Oppenheimer's entire life, the movie focuses on a more narrow portion of his life. The film portrays the gathering of the scientists to participate in the Manhattan Project, the work developing and testing the atomic bomb, and a hearing about Oppenheimer's security clearance years later. But it does not include the Japanese suffering as a result of the atomic bombs being dropped on Japan.

Additionally, large parts of the movie are depicted from the subjective point of view of Oppenheimer himself. When Universal Studios released Oppenheimer in Japan, the Japanese public was subjected to memories of World War 2 and the 210,000 Japanese citizens killed when atomic bombs were dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. The decision making to release the movie Oppenheimer in Japan paralleled the decision eighty years earlier to drop the atomic bombs in Japan. As both focused on the bottom line, were swayed by incrementalism, and centered on the perspective of the United States. As a result the negative reaction of the Japanese public to the movie was predictable.

While Oppenheimer was based on historical events, it omitted historical context like the physical and emotional damage done to Japanese people, which is important for assessing the possible success of the film in Japan. Universal Pictures' focus on bottom line results when airing Oppenheimer in Japan mirrored the bottom line focus of the decision makers to drop atomic bombs on Japan. The bottom line Universal Pictures' focused on was their profit margin, whereas the United States military focused on saving American lives and ending World War 2. Universal Pictures decided to release the movie in Japan on March 29, 2024, with the financial motive of making as much money as possible, without caring for the impacts of these actions on the Japanese population. Similarly, the decision makers in the American military were focused on their own bottom line of ending the war with the fewest number of American casualties.

On June 1, 1945, President Truman sent a Special Message to Congress on Winning the War with Japan. In it, Truman stated, "The primary task facing the Nation today is to win the war in Japan to win it completely and to win it as quickly as possible. For every day by which it is shortened means a saving of American lives."

In the quote above, Truman showed his focus on the bottom line of winning the war with the least amount of American casualties. Both Universal Pictures and the American military put their own success before the well-being of Japan. Focusing on the bottom line results when airing Oppenheimer in Japan mirrored the same focus of the decision to drop atomic bombs on Japan many years earlier.

When Universal Pictures decided to release Oppenheimer in Japan, it was likely influenced by incrementalist ideology, similar to the American military's decision to drop the bombs on Japan was also affected by incrementalism. In the year leading up to the dropping of the atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, the United States had been on a fire bombing campaign because Japan's wooden buildings were extremely susceptible to incendiary bombs. On March 9, 1945, American bombers burned nearly 16 square miles of Tokyo and killed an estimated 100,000 in one night (Cohen). Accordingly, the decision to drop the atomic bombs was only an incremental step forward from the firebombing campaign. For example, the atomic bomb killed 130,000 Japanese in Hiroshima and 80,000 Japanese in Nagasaki (Wellerstein).

Likewise, incrementalism affected the decision to release Oppenheimer in Japan. Since the end of World War 2, there had been dozens of American movies about the Pacific Front in World War 2, many of which were released in Japan. For example, Flags of Our Fathers was released in Japan in 2006, Hacksaw Ridge was released in Japan in 2017, and Midway was released in Japan in 2020. Therefore, taking it one step further by releasing a movie glorifying the man who created a bomb estimated to have killed 210,000 Japanese people, likely did not appear to Universal Pictures to be a drastic departure from prior practice.

The decision makers behind the content of Oppenheimer and the movie's release in Japan was made with little to no regard to the Japanese people's suffering from the United States dropping atomic bombs on Hiroshima on August 6, 1945, and Nagasaki on August 9, 1945. President Truman said in a speech on August 6, 1945, "We are now prepared to obliterate more rapidly and completely every productive enterprise the Japanese have above ground in any city. We shall destroy their docks, their factories, and their communications. Let there be no mistake; we shall completely destroy Japan's power to make war." In this speech, Truman detailed the exact purpose and power of the atomic bombs. Similar to the decision makers in the American military behind the dropping of the bombs, the decision makers behind the release of Oppenheimer in Japan likely looked at this decision from an American perspective. There was little concern given to what happened to the average Japanese citizen.

Yasujiro Tanaka, a survivor of the bomb dropped in Nagasaki stated "[M]ysterious scabs began to form all over my body. I lost hearing in my left ear... My younger sister suffers from chronic muscle cramps to this day." He mentioned his sisters asking "What did I do to the Americans?" and "Why did they do this to me?" These questions define the overall opinions and difference of perspectives between the average Japanese citizen and the average American citizen.



Yasujiro Tanaka - ICAN

Universal Pictures' decision to release Oppenheimer in Japan was influenced by incrementalism, similar to the American military's decision to drop the bombs on Japan.

With regard to the content of the movie, director Christopher Nolan dedicated very little time to showing the suffering of the Japanese people. The only acknowledgment of the horrors that occurred is during Oppenheimer's victory speech scene when he walks over a dead body. The slight nod to the suffering of the Japanese pales in comparison to what many Japanese people felt should be represented. Although Universal Pictures put warning placards outside theaters in Hiroshima and Nagasaki, the American centric perspective prevailed ([BBC](#)). The American centered decision making behind the content of Oppenheimer and the movie's release in Japan was similar to the choice made to drop the atomic bombs on Japan.

Given these historical antecedents and problematic decision making, the Japanese public's predictable reaction to Oppenheimer's release was mixed and largely negative. Many Japanese people felt like the movie skipped over the destruction the bombs caused. The Mayor of Hiroshima, Takashi Hiraoka, stated, "There could have been much more description and depiction of the horror of atomic weapons." Mayor Hiraoka believed the film should have portrayed more of the aftermath of the bomb, as as damaging as the actual dropping of it, with thousands succumbing to radiation poisoning. There is even a Japanese word for bomb survivors: hibakusha ([Guardian](#)). Having a word to designate survivors is a telling symbol of the effect the bombs have had on the culture. Many others believed that the way the film portrayed the bomb in such a positive and exciting light was humiliating.



NPR

But some Japanese people felt differently, believing that the movie educated them about a different perspective than what their school and society had taught them. Japanese schools do not teach from the American perspective, or communicate that the bomb saved countless lives. They are taught that it was a senseless decision that murdered hundreds of thousands of innocent civilians. One example of this viewpoint was Kanae Kume, who stated, "In the film they say that the use of the atomic bombs saved lives. When I heard that phrase I felt as if I had learned a new perspective from the American point of view and the World's point of view." Still, the majority of Japanese people believe the movie did not show enough suffering. Kawai, a resident of Hiroshima, reacted by stating, "the film also depicts the atomic bomb in a way that seems to praise it, and, as a person with roots in Hiroshima, I found it difficult to watch." All together, the Japanese public's mixed and largely negative reaction to the Oppenheimer release should have been expected given the history behind the topic and their problematic decision making.

In conclusion, the negative reactions of the Japanese public to the release of Oppenheimer was predictable because the decision making to release the movie in Japan paralleled the decision making to drop the actual atomic bombs in Japan. That decision making was characterized by its focus on the bottom line, incrementalism, and a United States centered perspective. *B*

CONTROLLING FOOD ENVIRONMENTS: HOW THE FOOD INDUSTRY'S MARKETING AND LOBBYING INFLUENCES THE AMERICAN DIET

By Alexa Warrin

I recently read *How the Other Half Eats: The Untold Story of Food and Inequality in America*, a book by sociologist Priya Fielding-Singh on the nutritional disparities in America, and took notice to many of her footnote asides that revealed her dissatisfaction with American food policy. Indeed, my interest in American nutrition and food industry regulation were what drew me to pick up the book in the first place.

Food and nutrition policy powerfully shapes the way we as Americans view and understand food. It influences the way we grocery shop and consume. America has lagged behind comparable nations in regard to nutrition and food policy for years due to corporate and political obstacles. Historically, economically powerful actors have controlled our food policy, our food environments, and our everyday consumption. Aggressive marketing to children and political lobbying are two of the ways the food industry has influenced our food preferences and federal dietary guidelines, negatively impacting public health and contributing to the obesity epidemic.



US SUN

Our 'toxic' food environment

Though the American diet has generally improved over time, we are nowhere near where we should be. According to one study, the country fell short of the 2010 Dietary Guidelines for Americans, optimal diet recommendations provided by the federal government, and by a considerable margin. Nearly half of all American adults have one or more chronic diseases related to poor quality diet.

Our everyday food choices, the ones that often lead Americans to diet-related diseases, are shaped by the "toxic" food environment we live in — the food made available to us at home by our parents, how far away we live to the nearest supermarket or fast-food restaurant, and the way the government supports farmers. In the U.S., our food environment — the physical and social factors that influence how we eat — makes it difficult to choose to eat healthy foods. We call our food environment "toxic" because of the way it eats away at public health and contributes to American obesity.

Furthermore, studies have made the link between poverty and obesity, with higher rates of obesity found in low-income and racial or ethnic groups in the U.S. There are often greater environmental, economic, and societal barriers to healthy eating for those with lower incomes.

Firstly, healthy foods (such as vegetables, fruits, and whole grains) are more expensive than less nutritious foods (refined grains and sweets), making them immediately less accessible and affordable for lower-income families. Time also poses a challenge to healthy eating: Nutritious, whole-food meals are more time-intensive to prepare than convenience foods or fast food, and people in low-income households, often single parents who work full time and take care of children, have less time to spare for meal preparation.

Lastly, access (or lack thereof) to grocery stores, convenience stores, and fast-food restaurants is also related to obesity. The term "food desert" has become popular to describe neighborhoods with limited access to grocery stores, or healthy and affordable food. Living in food deserts has been associated with lower quality diets and increased risk of obesity. Low-income neighborhoods, as well as predominantly Black or Hispanic neighborhoods, are less likely to have access to healthy and affordable food than middle-income and predominantly white neighborhoods. Moreover, convenience stores and fast-food restaurants are both more likely to be located in poor neighborhoods, and particularly near schools.



StoryMaps

The politics of food

The rise of neoliberal ideology in the late 20th and early 21st centuries as well as pressures from industry giants have encouraged the deregulation of food production and the agricultural sector.

Insufficient legislation around food marketing to children and industry lobbying has led to a food environment that is near impossible to navigate for American families and (intentionally) increased confusion around healthy eating.

Food industry marketing

Food and beverage companies in the U.S spend almost \$14 billion per year on food advertisements that appeal to children and adolescents, and that particularly target Black and Hispanic youth. More than 80% of this food advertising promotes fast food, sugary drinks, candy, and unhealthy snacks. Back in 2010, the World Health Organization (WHO) released a set of recommendations for regulating food marketing to children, but children today are still being invasively and incessantly exposed to marketing of foods high in fat, salt, and sugar.

There are still relatively few governmental policies in place to reduce food marketing to children. Congress stripped the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) of its authority to regulate marketing directed at children in 1980 after the FTC tried to limit sugary food and drinks in commercials during children's television. Instead, the FTC issues self-regulation guidelines for companies. But the lack of firm, required standards and government mandation has sustained the issue, and food companies have failed to self-regulate. A 2010 report found that two-thirds of 128 food and entertainment companies had no policy whatsoever on their marketing to children. FTC efforts to develop self-regulatory, but uniform nutrition standards for foods and drinks marketed to children have been met with strong resistance from industry and have been stalled by Congress.

Food marketing is associated with increasing children's food choices, preferences, purchase requests, and intake, and studies have shown that food marketing contributes to unhealthy diets and risk of poor health among American youth. More than a decade after members of the United Nations endorsed the WHO recommendations, children continue to be exposed to powerful marketing of unhealthy foods and beverages.

Though, while the U.S. has stalled to implement federal standards, many countries have taken action to reduce direct food marketing to children by restricting advertising that targets children under the age of 13 and 14 for fast food and unhealthy food products as well as banning the use of cartoons or toys when marketing unhealthy food. Reducing children's exposure to food marketing is an important strategy in addressing the American obesity epidemic.

Food industry lobbying

Within the federal government, there exists a conflict between guaranteeing federal protection of the rights of food lobbyists to act in their self-interest and the federal responsibility to promote public nutritional health. For example, since 1977, under pressure from meat producers, federal dietary advice has evolved from "decrease consumption of meat" to "have two or three (daily) servings." This incident highlights the inherent conflict of interest in the Department of Agriculture's dual mandates to promote U.S. agricultural products and to advise the public about healthy food choices.

Political lobbying, by shaping agricultural policy, can directly influence our food environments, our food choices, and our health.

Industry-funded research has historically been a way for companies to indirectly influence policy and public perception. One major example of this occurring was in the 1960s and 1970s, when the U.S. sugar industry funded research that downplayed the link between sugar and coronary heart disease in the 1960s and 1970s. The research “concluded” that the best way to address the disease was to cut out fat in American diets. And so a war on fat and cholesterol was sparked. In 1980, the first set of Dietary Guidelines for Americans was released by the U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) with a call to the public to reduce fat in their diets and eat more carbs.

With the low-fat principle governing the late 20th century, food companies seized the opportunity to churn out a whole new range of products — fat-free dairy products, fat-free snacks — that replaced the missing fat with loads of sugar, which, in the end, served to help the sugar industry profit enormously. In trying to address one problem, heart disease, the anti-fat, pro-carb dietary goals ultimately fueled other health problems, like obesity and diabetes. Since 1980, the number of Americans who are obese or have type-2 diabetes has more than doubled.



Food Unfolded

Food and Beverage companies spent a collective \$27.7 million on lobbying in 2023, lobbying about just about anything that could hurt their businesses, while the agribusiness sector spent \$178.3 million. Not to mention, there is a serious lack of transparency around food lobbying in the United States.

A number of leading nutrition experts say federal dietary guidelines are overly influenced by food manufacturers, food producers, and special interest groups. The 2015 guidelines, for example, were criticized for promulgating outdated research on the consumption of red and processed meat. They excluded a clear-cut advisory about limiting the consumption of red and processed meat, which studies had repeatedly linked to higher risk of heart disease, premature death, and cancer. The 2015 guidelines, which also said that average dairy intakes for most Americans were “far below” levels that fit into a “healthy U.S.-style pattern,” were not — and are not — congruent with the opinions of most nutrition experts on dairy consumption, raising further suspicion of industry influence.

U.S. Right to Know — a nonprofit public health research group — found that nine out of the 20 experts on the 2025 Dietary Guidelines Advisory Committee had financial or other ties over the past five years to food, pharmaceutical, grocery, and other industries. The report emphasized that conflicts of interest and industry influence undermine public confidence in U.S. dietary advice. These instances, furthermore, lead us to question why the USDA — the agency in charge of strengthening America’s food and agriculture industries, and whose primary stakeholders are major food producers and manufacturers — plays such a large role shaping American dietary guidelines and policies.

Food and climate change

To add to the complicated and worrisome situation, the climate impact of our current food supply is common knowledge. Improving nutrition policy is also key to addressing climate change, and inversely, declining climate health has a considerable impact on the nutritional value of our food supply.

Food supply has large impact on greenhouse gases, carbon emissions, and therefore climate change. The global food system, including production, processing, and distribution, accounts for approximately 26% of global greenhouse gas emissions, according to a 2018 study. Livestock or meat production, especially, heavily contributes to agricultural emissions. Studies show eating healthier and more plant-based diets can help us achieve a healthier planet.



Union of Concerned Scientists

Climate change also has the potential to decrease the quality, availability, and variety of the food supply. If, as a result, prices of healthy foods increase under climate change, economically disadvantaged groups will be less and less able to afford them, and instead turn to less expensive and more available but unhealthy foods, thus widening the nutritional disparity and strengthening the link between poverty and obesity.

Improving the situation

U.S. Right to Know offered various recommendations based on their analysis to address the adverse affects of political lobbying. They suggest that the USDA and HHS should avoid appointing members with “high-risk” conflicts of interest, extend the disclosure coverage period from one to five years, use a more transparent disclosure form, publish provisional appointees before they are appointed, and disclose roles at “conflicted nutrition organizations.”

The International Journal of Behavioral Nutrition and Physical Activity also laid out several “effective advocacy strategies” to improve nutrition policy. They argue that the government should implement policies that build towards creating food environments that enable children to adopt healthy preferences; food policies should strive to make the healthy choice the each and preferred choice.

To address inequality, food policies should be crafted to enable lower-income families to overcome the environmental and societal barriers to healthy eating. Well-designed food policies have the potential to have substantial and sustained long-term effects on obesity and public health. *B*

ART AND NATIONALISM: AN AMERICAN ORIGIN STORY

By Reese Fuhman

Art is often more powerful than the written record at documenting events and influencing the perspective of viewers. It gives us a glimpse into the emotional implications of historical events that may otherwise be lost in text. As a result, it is no surprise that art depicting iconic events of American history play a significant role in the way we view these events. Additionally, images are more effective at symbolism, and thus illustrate the ideological connotations ascribed to historical events.



Washington Crossing the Delaware, Emmanuel Leutze, 1851

For this reason, the artistic telling of historical events has influenced nationalist thinking. Simply put, nationalism is the identification with one's own country, but often encompasses the idea that geopolitical success is pre-ordained. Art of historical events advances this thinking because it utilizes symbolism in the portrayal of events, giving the impression that ideals are inherently present in historical action. By tracking art throughout American history, we can view and compare the principles artists chose to attribute to events, and see dominant ideologies of the time. In essence, throughout the course of American history, art has played a role in both representing and advancing nationalist ideals, thereby demonstrating the impact of art on public opinion.

In America today, we often look to the Revolution in order to understand our present through the lens of an historical origin. As a result, art depicting revolutionary events has become a central aspect of national identity, one that has taken on new meaning and significance over time. The painting *Washington Crossing the Delaware* by Emanuel Leutze is an example of a piece that has come to represent and amplify American ideals. This iconic work depicting Washington's attack on the Hessians at Trenton is repeatedly used to demonstrate American greatness and victory, showcasing core ideals at the basis of the American National identity.

The narrative of the victory of the revolutionary army as an underdog story is showcased in *Washington Crossing the Delaware*. In the painting, the boat is portrayed in treacherous waters, nonetheless, Washington's stance exudes confidence and his gaze is fixed on the land ahead. Although the army is struggling, Washington's facial expression highlights an unflinching belief in American victory.

This faith, despite threats, signifies that unwavering trust in America's success is a virtuous and patriotic deed. This is a common principle in nationalism today, as individuals think that unwavering belief in government action is the patriotic duty of a citizen.

Correspondingly, the presence of divine light throughout the work demonstrates the religious undertones of nationalist ideology. As Washington's army crosses the Delaware, yellow-tinted light and a bright sun arises from amid dark fog and shadows, shining on the army's boats. This artistic choice represents that America's actions are ordained by a higher power. As light is a representation of a divine being choosing to illuminate earthly beings. It is this belief system that served as a justification for colonization and manifest destiny later in history. This religious justification to explain and defend historical success is commonly used in nationalist thinking.

In addition, the painting depicts and justifies American hierarchical systems by picturing Washington above his army. In the work, Washington's head and body are illuminated in line with the American flag while the expressions of his army are below in darkness. Although his army is working to steer the boat, he is given higher status within the painting. The contributions of everyday citizens that made victory possible are overlooked and undervalued in favor of the idealization of a singular figure.

The resurgence of art depicting the American Revolution during the 19th century highlights how ideals were consolidated to create a shared national identity as the country expanded geographically and ideologically. This underscores that much of art depicting historical events was created to advance ideals rather than serve as a historical record, contributing heavily to American national identity.

As the United States expanded geographically, so too did the American identity. American Progress, painted in 1871 by John Gast, depicts how national identity became tied to the expansion of physical territory, scientific innovation and education.



American Progress, John Gast, 1871

Divine justification for the creation and success of the United States was extended through manifest destiny rhetoric used to justify geographical expansion. This work is a portrayal of manifest destiny ideals, which espoused the pre-ordainment of westward expansion, and cemented these principles visually. While industrialized cities are ethereally lit on the right side of the piece, Native American settlements and open plains lie in darkness. This is an artistic indication that industrialized American culture is more divinely favored than open plains, and by expanding influence settlers are “bringing light” to these darkened areas, thereby spreading the will of god.

In addition, Columbia - the angel-like female figure of America - is the one leading this development, signifying that westward expansion is not merely sanctioned but guided by divine powers (American Yawp).

Technological innovation and modernism are also a major component of the shift in light across the piece. Steam powered trains and wagons contrast Native Americans riding horses as light spreads in order to illustrate that this change was beneficial and divinely favored.

In addition, Columbia is artificially bringing light to these areas by stinging electrical lines across the landscape. This draws a connection between artificial light produced technologically and divine light, making the distinction that industrialization is a path towards god. This contrasts the traditionalism previously associated with religious thought and suggests that technological progress is divinely favored. Columbia also holds a book titled “school book,” indicating that educational expansion is another aspect of this divine modernization. This illustrates that education for all citizens became a new American priority, as principles of public education were advanced and during this time period.

In conclusion, the painting American Progress illustrates how religious connotations and artistic portrayals of Manifest Destiny led to the establishment of geographical expansion, technological modernization and education advancement as American ideals in the late nineteenth century.

Correspondingly, growth and modernization of the late 19th century ushered in a new American perspective in the 20th century. In the wake of World War One and in anticipation of World War Two, Norman Rockwell painted a series of posters titled “Four Freedoms.” These pieces sought to consolidate the central ideals of American freedom as defined by President Roosevelt’s 1941 State of the Union address (Houston Museum of Fine Art). One such work titled Freedom From Want, depicts the principles of wealth, plenty and family that grew to constitute American success in the mid-20th century.



Freedom From Want, Norman Rockwell, 1943

The scene portrays a family seated around a pristine white table; , they smile lovingly at one another while a grandmother sets a large turkey down. This scene showcases the burgeoning significance of the American family in national and political identity. After the human loss of the First World War, Americans became increasingly family oriented. As a result, the American family became a subject of greater importance within the political sphere.

The extent to which one was able to serve and support their family was a goal and indicator of financial success. In addition, as citizens acted politically with the motivation to protect their families, the idea of “traditional family values” as a political concept became increasingly important.

At the same time, the grandeur depicted in the piece, such as silver cutlery, white table cloths and abundant food highlights the increased significance of wealth as an ideal. As the mid-20th century saw the birth of a middle class, the scene depicted became accessible for the first time to a new class of Americans.

Consequently, consumerism grew in step to accommodate an increased appetite for luxury. The idea that Freedom From Want was a freedom to strive for underscores that abundance and wealth became a new aspiration. Being able to achieve success as defined by an ability to gain material objects and support one’s family became a new “American dream.” This work espouses what an American family is “supposed to look like” and was created with the goal to demonstrate what Americans are fighting for in times of war. As a result, it prioritizes material success and familial bliss as worthy patriotic aspirations. The irony of this piece is that with growing desires for wealth and status during the 20th century, Americans moved further from “freedom from want.” Overall, Freedom From Want illustrates the shift in American ideals that accompanied increased consumerism and the prioritization of the family unit in the mid-20th century.

As the American public has further come to terms with the legacy of harm in recent years, the view of works of art that glorify history has also shifted. The legacy of statues depicting colonizers and confederate generals has been fiercely debated, resulting in the removal of statues from many major cities.

Some artists have sought to replace these art pieces with statues that showcase a different perspective and challenge the power structures existing in much American art. As a result, the acknowledgment and rectification of past wrongs has become a new piece of American identity, one that in many ways pushes us to reexamine the grounding ideologies of America itself. Artist Kehinde Wiley, does just this, attempting to reclaim artistic narratives by putting African American people in positions of power dominantly ascribed to white people.

In his statue *Rumors of War* created in 2019, Wiley reclaims and subverts the motif of an equestrian statue by placing a black man in a historical position of power (Kehinde Wiley Studio). This statue, standing in Times Square, is similar in style and size to many of the confederate war memorials being taken down across the country.



Rumors of War, Kehinde Wiley, 2019

While the horse is heavily ornamented with details almost indistinguishable from confederate statues, the rider is dressed in modern day street style - a hoodie, ripped jeans, and Jordan shoes. His stance is powerful and victorious, illustrated by an arched back and stoic facial expression. Here, Wiley creates a juxtaposition between the historical motif of the horse and modern attributes of the rider. By doing so, he subverts historical power structures that have been used to rob African American people of power and dignity throughout American history.

The title of the statue, *Rumors of War*, extends this meaning. Throughout the historical record, but particularly during times of war, African American stories are pushed to the fringes of the narrative. Stories such as enslaved people fighting in the American Revolution or the segregated Black brigades in both world wars have been left to the backlog of history.

African American heroes who are mere rumors of the wars they died to win. This erasure continues because to fully recognize the impact of African Americans towards the success of the United States is to fully recognize their subjugation and erasure in the historical record. The location of this statue (in Times Square) facilitates a new American war narrative. With ever growing violence and crime plaguing urban communities, the struggle to survive and thrive itself is worthy of valorization. In addition, these ideas are able to be seen by a large audience in an urban center, and play a role in exposing the American public to alternate perspectives. Overall, through his statue *Rumors of War*, Kehinde Wiley subverts the American historical legacy and shines light upon a new age of American victory stories.

In conclusion, art has proved a powerful tool in both demonstrating and spreading nationalist ideals throughout American history. But can art really be the basis of a national identity? Often the ties one feels to their country in the form of nationalism are emotional in nature, born from memories or experiences which make events personally charged. For this reason, art can serve as a powerful tool to unite individuals under a common principle - such as nationalism - because it allows for the sharing of an emotional experience through art. As a result, it is no wonder that propaganda is largely successful at inciting shared political belief, because emotion influences thought and art curates a collective emotional response for those who view it. *B*

THE DECLINE OF NASCAR

By Owen Xu



Autosport

NASCAR's popularity has been on the decline since the mid-2000s. Once the second-most popular sport in America, it seemed poised to eclipse even the NFL in terms of viewership. However, NASCAR failed to capitalize on its gaining popularity, eventually fading back into obscurity. In 2023, NASCAR averaged 3.3 million viewers per race, a steep decline from the 5.8 million the sport averaged in 2012. ([Thapa](#)) The decline in viewership for the sport's largest race, the Daytona 500, was even sharper, with ratings dropping from 19.36 million in 2006 to a comparatively minor 8.2 million in 2023 ([Statista](#)). This article will examine the numerous reasons for NASCAR's decline, explaining how each action or behaviour influenced this purported downfall.

Firstly, NASCAR's in-race mismanagement contributed greatly to the sport's decline. NASCAR's style of officiating and recent rule changes have angered fans and drivers alike, making them less willing to watch the sport. For example, whenever a driver would gain a large lead, near the end of the race, NASCAR would often throw a "debris" caution flag to bunch the field together and produce closer racing, an underhanded tactic with the sole purpose of making races unnaturally close.

The number of debris cautions increased from 0.5 per race in 1998 to almost 2.5 per race in 2005 ([Racing-Reference](#)), a 5x increase in a mere 7 years. These cautions changed the outcome of many races, which angered fans not only because drivers were wrongly deprived of a win but also since the interference from officiating bodies meant the race was seen as "artificial." One of the most egregious examples of "debris cautions" came in the 2015 race at Auto Club Speedway. The race had 5 debris cautions, three of which were within the last 10 laps of the race. As a result, Kurt Busch, who looked set for a win before the cautions, agonizingly lost out on victory to Brad Keselowski. These debris cautions tarnished NASCAR's image, as more fans started to view NASCAR as inauthentic entertainment rather than truly competitive sport.

Another way NASCAR contributed to their own decline was mismanaging the wishes of their fanbase via unpopular rule changes and an unsavory attitude towards fans in the media and otherwise. In the early 2000s, the NASCAR champion for the season was determined by a season-long points format, where whoever scored the most points over the course of the 36-race season would become the champion.

While this may have resulted in champions being crowned well before the end of the season (in a four year stretch from 1998 to 2001, every champion was mathematically determined one race before the end of the season), it was an objective and fair determination of who the champion would be. However, NASCAR, thinking that the format needed a change, introduced the Chase for the Cup in 2004.

A revolutionary new points system, the Chase for the Cup took the top 10 drivers in the first 26 races of the season and reset their points, resulting in a 10 race “chase” where the best-performing driver out of those top 10 drivers over the course of those last 10 races would win the championship. This resulted in drivers trying to “game” the system: Jimmie Johnson in particular was notorious for “cruising” through the 26-race “regular season,” utilizing the regular season as a test period where new setups, aero improvements, and ideas were tested. Only during the last 10 races would Jimmie Johnson and his crew put their acts together and compile the experimental data they got in the first 26 races to win over their opponents. Indeed, this strategy worked wonders for Johnson; he won 5 championships in a row from 2006 to 2010 (to emphasize what an achievement this was, no other driver has won even 4 championships in a row). While this is undoubtedly a remarkable strategy by Johnson and his team, it placed doubts on the integrity of these five championships and this new format in general.

Johnson was clearly not the best driver over the course of the season in many ways, but he still ended up winning the championship. Additionally, many NASCAR fans still argue that Jeff Gordon’s performances during the 2007 season and Carl Edwards’ performances during the 2008 season were superior to Johnson’s performances in those seasons, but thanks to the Chase for the Cup format, Johnson still managed to prevail over Gordon and Edwards. Thus, the Chase for the Cup was seen as a kind of “gimmick”.

Many fans and drivers showed their displeasure with this format. In one forum from 2007, a fan stated that the Chase is an example of “NASCAR becoming a greedy money monster,” ([racing-forums](#)). 2003 Champion Matt Kenseth said that “if you start it at zero with 10 races to go, I don't like that idea at all... I don't think a champion should be rewarded off of how good they are at a mile-and-a-half race track. I think it still needs to reward the team and driver that can do the best at all the different race tracks.” ([Motorsport.com](#)) These signs of discontent and displeasure also became clearer as the novelty of the format wore off and Johnson went on his unprecedented 5-year run of dominance. TV ratings started to decline after around 2006, as average Daytona 500 viewership declined from around 20 million to just over 13 million over a space of 4 years (Statista).



CNN

However, NASCAR failed to address this, instead choosing to double down on the policies that first catalyzed its decline. In 2014, NASCAR implemented a new playoff format where drivers would be systematically eliminated from championship contention until the last race, where the highest finishing driver of those still in the championship would win the Cup.

This brought even more scrutiny and discontent, as NASCAR not only ignored the suggestions and criticisms of Kenseth and other drivers and fans, but in fact implemented policies that seemingly did the opposite of what they suggested. Although official reaction (NASCAR “used data from NASCAR’s fan council” to fuel this decision) from drivers and fans seemed to be generally positive at the time (most likely for reasons discussed in the next paragraph), the reaction from most fans and drivers was negative. This change in format would do little to stop NASCAR’s imminent decline, as ratings continued to dip, reaching record lows in 2018. ([ESPN](#))

Another way NASCAR soured their relationship with their fans was through their fan council. Initially thought of as a way for fans to directly communicate with NASCAR, many fans eventually found the fan council to be manipulative. Questions in fan council surveys were often phrased in a way such that fans are forced to answer in the way that NASCAR wants them to. For example, one question on a fan council survey asked whether fans wanted “more side-by-side racing with less horsepower” or “less side-by-side racing with more horsepower,” clearly wanting the people surveyed to show preference to lower horsepower. ([Weaver](#)) Thus, fans started to get the impression that NASCAR did not truly care about fan opinion, and were only using fans to push their own narratives on how the sport should progress. Thus, fans stopped watching the sport, as they felt alienated from NASCAR through the fan council and NASCAR’s attitude towards fans.

Another reason for NASCAR’s decline is the decrease in enthusiasm, charisma, and relatability of the drivers competing in the sport.

Drivers such as Dale Earnhardt and Darrell Waltrip, who had distinct personalities which garnered emotions from fans, slowly faded away from the sport, while drivers such as Jeff Gordon and Jimmie Johnson, who, while very good drivers, showed little personality off-track.

One reason for this decrease in charisma and relatability is the increased scrutiny placed on drivers by fans amid the rise of social media. The advent of social media made sharing information a lot easier: instead of waiting for a newspaper to report the latest news or a friend to text you updates, one can simply look on Twitter or Instagram and see the latest updates in seconds. Due to this ease of access, NASCAR drivers (and other celebrities) are pressured to conform to media norms in two ways.

First, since information can be more easily transmitted, more of this information gets shared to the public. This means that almost anything a driver says or does will be shared with the Internet, and thus, the world. Thus, if a driver does something perceived as bad, there is a much greater chance that this action will become public, and thus, a much greater chance that negative consequences will arise. For example, in August of 2023, after it was found that he liked a potentially offensive Instagram reel, Noah Gragson was stripped of his ride at Legacy Motor Club (a NASCAR team, not a luxury club as the name suggests) and suspended indefinitely from NASCAR. Before the advent of social media, it was unlikely that information such as what Instagram reels a driver liked (or the pre-social media equivalent) would have reached the public eye. Thus, in the pre-social media era, there is a lower chance that Gragson would have been suspended, as the information that led to his suspension most likely would have not been available to the public.

The second way that NASCAR drivers are pressured to conform to media norms is through the echo-chamber that social media nurtures. Due to the algorithms of social media, the posts that receive the most reactions spread the most quickly and are the most available. This is understandable; if many who have already viewed something react to it, it is more likely that someone who has not viewed it would react to it as well. However, this leads to posts being made trying to “game the algorithm:” people post opinions and information that they know people will like/react to, even if they themselves do not agree with what they are posting. These posts inevitably receive many reactions, as these posts were made with that purpose in mind.



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Social media algorithms favour these posts, meaning that more people will see these posts. Thus, more people will form their opinions based on these posts, which leads to more people posting the same or similar opinions. A positive feedback loop is created, and eventually, one particular opinion would become dominant in social media. Due to this feedback loop, it becomes easy for opinions to become negative, extreme, and overblown: more outlandish and more negative and pessimistic opinions are more likely to receive reactions.

Opinions in social media become both negative and radical, which means social media reactions to a driver's actions are more likely to be negative and radical. A driver becomes less inclined to say or do things that stand out and give social media something to grasp onto.

This increased scrutiny of drivers isn't just from fans, however, as sponsors also place similar pressure on drivers. Anything a driver does that could tarnish their own image would tarnish a sponsor's image as well. As the sponsor is associated with a certain driver, if the driver is viewed in a negative light, the sponsor will be too. Most of the time, the sponsor does not want this negative light shed on them, as the purpose of sponsoring a driver is to promote their image, not degrade it. Thus, the sponsor places pressure on the driver, forcing them to even further conform to norms and become more “corporate.”

These sponsors include not only conventional sponsors that sponsor individual drivers such as Lowe's and McDonald's, but also NASCAR itself. NASCAR gets publicity from the actions of their drivers, so if many of their drivers are viewed in a negative light, NASCAR itself will be viewed similarly. Additionally, due to the effects of social media described above, anything a driver says about NASCAR itself is far more likely to reach the public eye. Thus, NASCAR places pressure on drivers to reduce outspoken criticism of the sport, as it is far more likely to reflect negatively on NASCAR's image. For example, Denny Hamlin was fined \$25,000 in 2013 for criticizing the new Generation 6 race car that made its debut that year. Thus, NASCAR drivers are prompted to curb their personalities, as fans, sponsors, and the NASCAR sanctioning body itself place tons of pressure on them.



Speed Sport

Lastly, NASCAR's decline can also be attributed to the increased price to compete in the sport. First, this increased price to compete means that smaller teams will be less able to compete in the sport. In 2016, NASCAR introduced a charter system, where teams with a charter are guaranteed and required to compete in all 38 race events, and in return, they get a higher share of NASCAR's revenue for the season. Although it is possible to run a full-time entry without a charter (Ryan Preece did so in 2021), running such an entry is unsustainable, as it is not guaranteed that the entry qualifies for every race and the entry gets less revenue. Thus, having a charter is a necessity if one is to start a new race team. Since these charters are limited, they are extremely expensive. In 2023, Spire Motorsports purchased a charter for \$40 million ([Romine and Long](#)). Thus, a smaller team without this kind of funding is essentially locked out of the sport, which means that fans have fewer small teams to root for as underdogs. Fans love an underdog story, and without these smaller teams, there are fewer opportunities for such a story.

Additionally, NASCAR's economic model also makes it hard for even the most established teams to sustain themselves. Indeed, even Hendrick Motorsports, the most successful NASCAR team, is unable to turn a profit. Jeff Gordon, vice-chairman of Hendrick Motorsports, stated that it has been "a while" since Hendrick last made a profit and that "where [Hendrick Motorsports is] currently at is not sustainable." ([Long](#))

After each race, NASCAR gives only 25% of TV revenue to teams, which is nowhere near enough for a team to sustain itself. Thus, 60-80% of a NASCAR team's revenue has to come from sponsorships (around 10% of an MLB team's revenue is from sponsorships, and around 25% of a Premier League team's revenue is from sponsorships). This makes a NASCAR team's revenue stream much more volatile and unpredictable, as any changes in sponsorship could lead to a team losing a significant portion of their revenue, and could potentially lead to the team's inability to compete in NASCAR. External investors much less likely to invest in a sport with such a fickle revenue, making NASCAR unable to reap the benefits of these external investors.

This revenue model makes NASCAR teams much more dependent on these sponsors, meaning that sponsors have the ability to severely influence teams. Many top teams, especially in the lower series, have "pay drivers." While these "pay drivers" may not be able to compete at the same level as their teammates, they provide sponsorship for the team, and as sponsorship is so important in NASCAR, their spot on the team is essentially guaranteed. For example, in 2021, Matt DiBenedetto was kicked out of his ride at the Wood Brothers Racing team, with the Wood Brothers choosing Harrison Burton instead. Although DiBenedetto was clearly a good driver, giving the Wood Brothers some of their best results in decades, Burton provided funding, which meant that despite him finishing 27th and 31st in points (out of 32 full-time drivers) in his first two years in the team, his spot on the team was secure.

Thus, the sport's competitiveness is limited, as many spots on many teams are taken by drivers that provide funding instead of those with the most pure racing skill. Thus, NASCAR fans become less willing to watch the sport, as the sport is less competitive through the increased importance of sponsorship. *B*